

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Hundreds of Millions Affected

1 in 3

women

will experience major depression in their lifetime

1 in 5

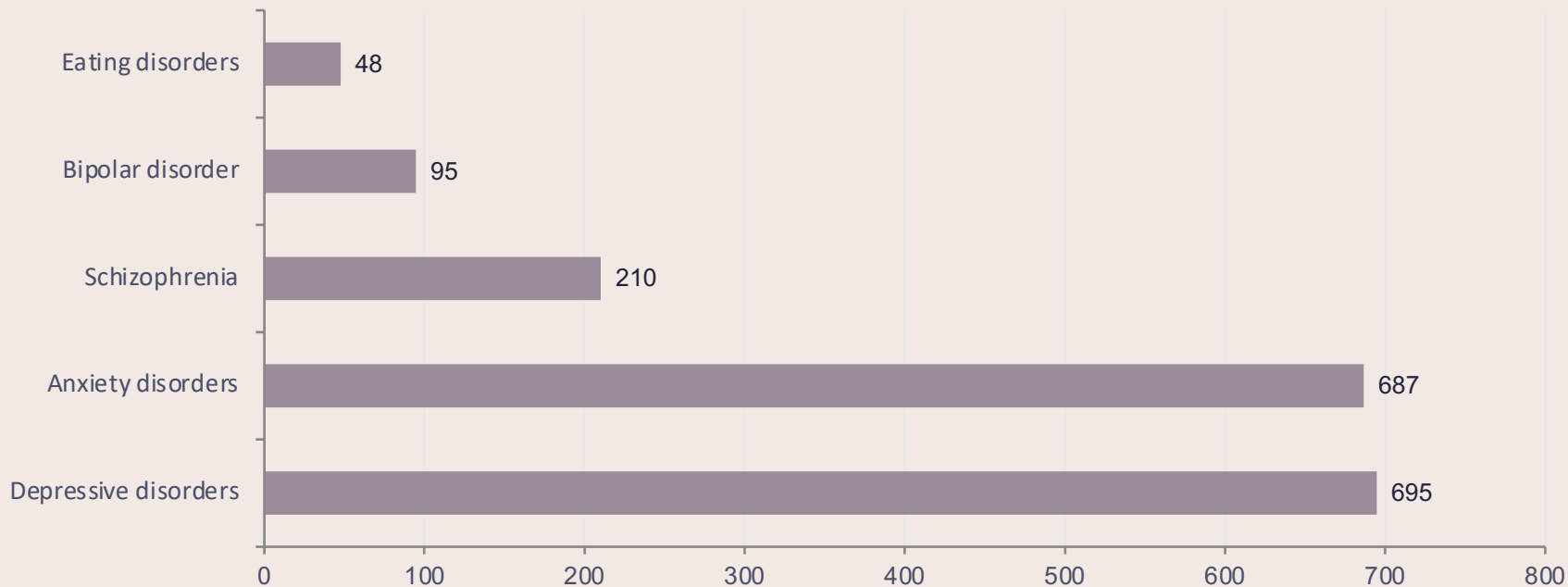
men

will experience major depression in their lifetime

Other conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder are less common but have a large impact on individuals' lives.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate Disease Burden

DALYs per 100,000 people, World 2023



Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease 2023

Depression and Anxiety: Nearly Equal Burden

Combined, they account for ~80% of mental health DALYs

Depressive
disorders



694
.6

Anxiety
disorders



686
.5

Together, Depression and Anxiety represent the overwhelming majority of mental health disease burden worldwide

Difference: only 8.1 DALYs per 100,000

Schizophrenia and Bipolar: Lower Prevalence, High Individual Impact

Depression: 126.4 DALYs

Bipolar Disorder: 94.6 DALYs

Schizophrenia: 210.2 DALYs

Key Insight

Schizophrenia carries disproportionately high individual burden relative to its prevalence.

While population-level burden is lower, individual severity and disability are high.

210

DALYs

DALY = Disability-Adjusted Life Years (per 100,000 population)

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

1

Stigma

Many people feel uncomfortable disclosing mental health symptoms

2

Access

Treatment often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries

3

Quality

Even where treatment exists, may be of poor quality

4

Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes prevalence hard to estimate

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family

1

Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where access to healthcare professionals is more available

2

Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide, providing community and meaning

3

Friends and Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across almost all cultures and settings

Note: Responses vary widely across countries and cultures

Key Takeaways for Policy

- ✓ Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs (each ~690 per 100K)
- ✓ Schizophrenia and bipolar carry disproportionate individual burden relative to prevalence
- ✓ Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate in many regions
- ✓ Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data
- ✓ Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions